



Przewalski's wild horse

Equus przewalskii

For centuries, these stocky mammals grazed grassy plains ranging from Germany to China and Mongolia, but due to severe winters, habitat loss, and excessive hunting, their numbers fell during the 18th century. In 1969, the species was declared extinct in the wild. Thanks to cooperative captive breeding programs in Europe, the US, and Australia, since 1985 small herds have been reintroduced to China, Mongolia, Kazakhstan, and Ukraine. Today, more than 300 Przewalski's wild horses roam their historic range in Mongolia.

Dangerous union

Although closely related, Przewalski's differ from domestic horses at a genetic level: they have 66 chromosomes in each body cell, while domestic horses have 64. The two species can interbreed, producing fertile offspring, and interbreeding is considered a major threat to the remaining Przewalski's wild horses. Physical differences from domestic horses include a smaller, more compact body; a shorter, thicker neck; a short, erect mane; and all individuals being the same color.

In the wild, Przewalski's horses constantly roam in search of water and the short grasses that form the bulk of their diet. Herds consist of a dominant stallion, a harem of one to three females, and their offspring, which stay with the family group for two to three years.

All pure Przewalski's wild horses alive today are descended from just 12 individuals



△ FIGHTING FOR DOMINANCE

If ritualized signaling fails to deter a bachelor challenger, the dominant stallion will defend his right to lead a harem by fighting, often resulting in severe injuries.

▷ MOTHER AND FOALS

Foals stay close to their mothers for food, warmth, and protection against predators such as wolves. Sometimes, herds join forces in search of food.

